

Reviving Civic Engagement with Citizen Advisory Boards

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Town council meetings and citizen advisory boards too often become forums dominated by a few well-connected residents. The fix isn't more engagement opportunities — it's more representative ones.

Drawing on social capital theory, the piece argues that local governments can disrupt homogeneous, exclusionary civic networks by deliberately building advisory boards that connect people across different backgrounds and power structures — and by giving those boards real influence in the decision-making process, not just a ceremonial seat at the table.

THREE TYPES OF SOCIAL CAPITAL

Bonding

Relationships among people with similar backgrounds or group membership.

Bridging

Relationships connecting people or groups with differing backgrounds.

Linking

Networks that connect people across power dynamics, expanding access to resources.

The NC Main Street Program's Downtown Advisory Boards serve as a real-world example: communities where citizens collaborate directly with town staff and elected officials on downtown revitalization, building exactly the kind of bridging and linking capital the piece calls for.